In response to your Leader...

South Downs Woodturners

Hi Mark,
I just read your December Leader about clubs and thought I should respond. Regarding the number of members attending South Downs Woodturners – it's random. We keep an eye on total attendance to see if we are achieving our target as we are a new-ish club – just when I think I have spotted a pattern, I check the previous year only to find there isn't one. Our attendance, on the first Thursday each month, is generally pretty good at between 56 and 89%, with an average of 71%. Attendance at all-day Saturday demos is, however, less good at 40–48%.

Competitions are interesting, as I have spoken to many members at different clubs, and the most common reason for not entering has been negative comments by judges. I have also heard gripes about restrictive stipulations and, at one club, moving goalposts. At South Downs Woodturners we tried to maximise entries by providing broad topics with few, if any, restrictions, and giving judges some guidance. However, it's very difficult because one minute we are asking judges to decide between pieces of work, where inevitably you have to pick out the faults, and then provide comment to members in a positive way. We have asked our judges to refrain from any public comments on the work, just announcing the results for each of the groups. We do, however, offer individual feedback to anyone who would like it. We have four competitions each year, one of which is 'Freestyle', i.e. open to any turning. At our Freestyle competition we ask all members to vote for their preferred item, which works quite well.

We have other methods of trying to get people to bring in their work, such as a Tools 'n' Turnings table where we encourage members to bring in completed items, works in progress, tools, etc. This works reasonably well if we prime someone to put something out, then others seem to put things they have brought there also. Without priming, however, it's been less successful.

I have recently introduced a Chairman's Challenge. The concept is to give a brief one month in advance and encourage broad interpretation. The first month was 'Branch', and much to my surprise we had a good number of entries, 19 (about the same as a competition), and a significant range of items. I select one or more item, make a brief positive comment and give the owner a small token for participating. I have made it clear it's not a competition, and I highlight elements that I find interesting rather than simply picking the best piece.

And, of course, we run hands-on evenings where we encourage participation, though I see that as more of a precursor to full member demonstrations.

If you know of any other way of encouraging members to show their work at meetings, I would be interested to hear them.

Regards
Chris Grace
Chairman, South Downs Woodturners
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P.S. Our 89% attendance was when you demonstrated!

Weston Woodturning Circle

Dear Mark,
Further to your Leader, I thought I would drop you a few lines about our club, Weston Woodturning Circle, based in Weston-super-Mare. It is regrettable that some clubs are suffering when it comes to 'show and tell'. We too have had our moments but over the past year or so we have seen an increase in participation.

There have been reasons why we still get the odd night when things could be better, some being holidays, lack of opportunity to get into the workshop, other priorities or even the subject matter. For example, one month the theme was 'thread chasing', which followed on from the previous month's professional demo. This takes specialist tools and only two of our members had them – lesson learnt.

The turnout for our 'show and tell' is very good and I put this down to several things:

- We encourage everyone to take part, from those who have just started to those who have been turning for years.
- We never criticise or put anyone down.
- We will give constructive opinions if asked, and many do.
- Everyone takes an interest when items are being presented and it has become an important part of our evening.
- And finally, a good round of applause and thanks at the end to all.

By doing it this way we have found that everyone, especially those who have been turning for a short time, build up the confidence to stand up in front of the group and know they will get plenty of support and encouragement.

We are a small club with just over 40 members who go along to our monthly meetings to enjoy ourselves and have fun. Knowing everyone is made welcome and made to feel part of the club makes it enjoyable for all. This is how I believe club nights should be.

Kindest regards
Greg Keenan
Secretary, Weston Woodturning Circle

FROM THE FORUM

'Winter Songs' pot in ash (*Fraxinus excelsior*) by Andrea Zanini

Burr elm (*Ulmus procera*) ball form by Bob Chapman

CHJ's lidded box in oak (*Quercus robur*) and walnut (*Juglans regia*)